🌻 Tasks 2 & 3 – Introduction

Chapter contents.

9 Oct 2025

What this folder is for

> In the previous chapter we introduced **minimalist causal coding**:

- we code **links** between named factors (plain-language labels)
- we let **factor labels** do most of the work (e.g. `wealth` vs `poverty`)
- we start from a **links table** (one row per coded causal claim), rather than building a separate factor metadata structure

That approach has general applicability. This folder collects a set of **practical extensions** that make the approach more useful for answering common evaluation questions — mainly by simplifying, querying, and comparing the map.

All the extensions in this folder are implemented in the Causal Map app, but the ideas are tool-independent.

As you read:

- start with the practitioner sections ("what is this for / how do I interpret it?")
- where a page needs more formal material, it's placed at the bottom under **Formal notes (optional)**

© Causal Map Ltd 2026 · causalmap.app · CC BY-NC 4.0

Formal notes (optional)

If you want deeper theory/background (not required for using the method):

- Ideas Garden: Minimalist coding for causal mapping
- Ideas Garden: A formalisation of causal mapping

PAGES IN THIS CHAPTER

Combining links into bundles

> In most projects, the data contains many repeated causal claims with the **same cause and the same effect** (often across many sources). We call these **bundles** (or **co-terminal link bundles**).

Extension - co-terminal link bundles

> In most projects, the data contains many **co-terminal links**: multiple coded claims with the **same cause and the same effect**. We call these **bundles of links**.

The factors table

> The factors table is a **summary view** of your map: it tells you which factors are most prominent in the current view of the data, and how that changes across groups.

Path tracing and source tracing

> This extension is for when you want to understand **how one factor connects to another through intermediate steps**.

Reporting global and local network statistics

> This extension is about **summarising a causal map as a network** using simple statistics.

Reporting global and local network statistics

> This extension is about **summarising a causal map as a network** using simple statistics.

Simplification - factor and link frequency

> This extension is about **simplifying** a causal map by keeping only the **most frequently mentioned**:

 © Causal Map Ltd 2026 · causalmap.app · CC BY-NC 4.0

Exclude links based on group or other metadata

This extension is about filtering links using **metadata** (information attached to links and/or their sources), not just factor labels.

Exclude links based on group or other metadata

This extension is about filtering links using **metadata** (information attached to links and/or their sources), not just factor labels.

Focus or exclude factors

This extension is about using **factor labels** to carve out a useful subgraph of your causal map.

Collapsing factor labels and excluding brackets

This extension is about **using factor labels to unify many "different-looking" factors into one**.

Path tracing and source tracing

Path tracing is for answering questions like:

Hierarchical coding

When you code lots of sources, you quickly end up with **too many near-duplicate causes and effects** (and therefore too many nodes on the map). Hierarchical factor labels let you keep the detail *and* produce a smaller "summary map" by "zooming out" to a higher level.

Hierarchical coding

When you code lots of sources, you quickly end up with **too many near-duplicate causes and effects** (and therefore too many nodes on the map). Hierarchical factor labels let you keep the detail *and* produce a smaller "summary map" by "zooming out" to a higher level.

Opposites

Opposites coding is for when your data naturally contains paired factors like:

Plain coding

Causal mapping doesn't usually deal with the kind of non-causal themes which are the focus of ordinary QDA (like in NVivo!). However sometimes it can be really useful to be able to simply note the presence of something

 © Causal Map Ltd 2026 · causalmap.app · CC BY-NC 4.0

without any causal connection.

Focus or exclude factors

This extension is about using **factor labels** to carve out a useful subgraph of your causal map.

Collapsing factor labels and excluding brackets

This extension is about **using factor labels to unify many "different-looking" factors into one**.

Comparing groups and testing the differences

How can we use a **factors table** to summarise a causal map, compare groups (districts, gender, questionnaire sections, etc.), and decide which differences are worth attention?

The factors table

This extension builds a **factors table** from the (already filtered) **links table**.

© Causal Map Ltd 2026 · causalmap.app · CC BY-NC 4.0